

If you notice sick or dead birds or other animals, you should not touch them. If there are multiple sick or dead birds or other animals, take photos or a video.

Record your location and report it to the 24-hour Emergency Animal Disease Hotline on 1800 675 888.

If you have pet birds or backyard chickens, there are simple steps you can take to help protect your birds.

Keep watch for signs of bird flu

Signs of bird flu usually appear in several or all birds in a flock, including:

- sudden death
- lethargy or reluctance to walk, eat or drink
- droopy appearance or ruffled feathers
- head or limb swelling
- bruising of the wattle, comb, feet or skin
- respiratory signs such as panting, nasal discharge or sneezing
- diarrhoea
- unusual head or neck posture, incoordination, inability to walk or stand
- unusual reduction in egg production.

Avian influenza can only be confirmed through laboratory testing of samples collected by a veterinarian or government animal health officer.

If you notice something unusual, talk to your local vet or call the Emergency Animal Disease hotline on 1800 675 888.

Take steps to protect your birds

H5 bird flu spreads easily and can infect backyard poultry and pet birds through:

- contact with infected wild birds or feral chickens
- contaminated clothing, shoes, equipment, egg cartons, or vehicles.

If you own backyard poultry or other birds, these simple steps will help protect them

Keep your equipment and enclosures clean

- Remove litter, sand and grit from the aviary between batches of birds, and every few months for resident birds.
- Thoroughly clean concrete floors, walls and aviary wire with soapy water. Apply disinfectant after cleaning.
- Clean and disinfect feed and water containers regularly.

- Don't share equipment with other birdkeepers unless it has been thoroughly cleaned and disinfected.

Prevent contact between your birds and wild birds

- Prevent contact with wild birds by restricting access to open ponds, lakes and creeks. Protective netting or keeping them housed can help prevent wild birds from mingling with yours. Some options for housing include coops and aviaries.
- Clean up surrounding areas to reduce shelter and hiding places for wild birds.

Keep feed and water clean

- Ensure water supplied to birds is from a chlorinated mains water supply or a clean bore. If these sources aren't available use water that has been properly treated (see the [Water Biosecurity Manual](#)).
- Don't allow wild birds or pest animals to contaminate your birds feed. Store it in a container with a secure lid.

Practice good hygiene

- Always thoroughly wash your hands with soap before and after handling birds.
- Clean your footwear and wash clothing regularly. Avoid using the same clothing and footwear around your own birds if you have visited other flocks or events such as shows.
- Do not take any birds to a show if there are signs of illness in your flock.
- All bird equipment and permanent carrying containers should be cleaned and disinfected before and after a show.
- At the show, avoid handling birds other than your own, if possible.
- At home, show birds should always undergo a period of quarantine before returning to the flock.
- Keep a register of all bird movements onto and off your properties.

Limit visitor access

- Restrict access to bird areas.
- Ask visitors to wash their hands. Practice good hygiene and put on clean protective clothing. Use footbaths containing the correct disinfectants at the entrance to bird areas or sheds.
- Keep a record of visitors, including any movement between poultry farms.

Quarantine new birds

- Separate and monitor new birds for at least 30 days before introducing them to your existing flock.
- Always source birds from a reputable producer or breeder whose bird health status is known.
- Always buy healthy birds and avoid buying them from markets.
- Feed and clean quarantined birds after you have tended to other birds.

Watch

Bird shows

There is an increased risk of disease spreading at exhibitions because birds are brought in from many states and towns.

Resources

Help you protect your bird at shows.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/pests-diseases-weeds/animal/avian-influenza/help-protect/bird-owners>